

2026 Primary Election Candidate Questionnaire

Complete Candidate Responses

Western Queens Community Land Trust • wqclt.org • Democratic Primary: Tuesday, June 23, 2026

This document contains candidates' complete written responses to the questions covered in WQCLT's 2026 Voter Guide. Responses are presented as submitted — spelling, grammar, and phrasing have not been corrected — and are organized by race, with candidates in alphabetical order. Some questionnaire items were designated for WQCLT's internal planning and are not published.

An identical questionnaire was sent to every candidate WQCLT could reach beginning May 15, 2026, with follow-ups through early June. Candidates not included here did not return a completed questionnaire by the publication deadline.

WQCLT is a nonpartisan community organization and does not support or oppose any candidate for public office. This document is provided for voter education only.

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The Questions

Question 1 — Growth and displacement

Western Queens is undergoing rapid change. The OneLIC rezoning alone could bring over 14,000 units of new housing and the loss of an estimated 800,000 square feet of manufacturing space. LIC will have even less open space per capita (currently 3rd lowest out of 51 neighborhoods citywide). How would you balance this unprecedented growth in LIC with protecting existing residents, manufacturers, and artists from displacement, and expanding waterfront green space?

Question 2 — Public land, subsidies, and privatization

We believe that public land should serve the public, and that publicly-owned sites in Western Queens represent a rare opportunity to invest in permanently affordable housing, community space, and small-scale manufacturing rather than luxury development. What principles would guide your approach to the future of public land and public buildings in our neighborhood, including the use of public subsidies and privatization?

Question 3 — The Anable Basin public sites

There are three public sites in Anable Basin (44-59 45th Ave DOT Facility, 44-36 Vernon Blvd DOE Building, 4-99 44th Drive parking lot) that have been upzoned and designated for disposition as part of OneLIC. How do you think these properties should be developed? (Please select as many options as you like.) Candidates were then invited to explain their selections.

- No transfer of public land to private ownership of any kind.
- Deeply affordable housing (developed by not-for-profits, no market-rate units, all at AMIs below 60%)
- Market-rate housing (Mixed-income developer-built housing with existing MIH levels)
- No new housing in the floodplain
- Community space
- Below market-rate commercial/retail space (subsidized and/or affordable to small businesses, working artists and nonprofits)
- Market-rate commercial space
- Mixed-use housing, community and light manufacturing space
- Industrial/working artist/light manufacturing space
- New school
- Open public green space/park
- Waterfront public access
- Resilient waterfront green infrastructure (such as strategic retreat, seawalls, elevating shorelines, & wetlands) to mitigate flooding and sea level rise
- Working port/Blue highway

Question 4 — The 44-36 Vernon Blvd building

Candidates were asked about WQCLT's feasibility study and response to the NYC Economic Development Corporation's RFEI for the 44-36 Vernon Blvd site, which proposes converting the city-owned building into a deeply affordable, multi-tenant space supporting arts and culture, light manufacturing, workforce development, nonprofit social services, and community retail, rather

than demolishing it for housing. Candidates' written responses to this item appear under “On the 44-36 Vernon Blvd building” in each candidate's section.

Question 5 — The floodplain and resiliency

How should the city and state approach housing and development in this floodplain, and what role should public resiliency infrastructure play versus individual protections built by private developers?

New York's 7th Congressional District

U.S. House of Representatives • Democratic Primary, June 23, 2026

Also on the June 23 ballot: Alexander Campagna, Steven Carbajal, Evan Hutchison, Sydney Martinez, Dane-Brandon Noble, Edwin Osorio, Paperboy Prince, Miles Shore. WQCLT did not receive completed questionnaires from these candidates by the publication deadline.

Vichal Kumar

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On growth and displacement

I've spent 20 years representing the people who get displaced when neighborhoods change. Tenants pushed out after a rezoning. Small businesses that can't afford the new commercial rents. Workers who lose their jobs when their building becomes luxury condos. I know what displacement looks like because I've sat across from the families living through it. 14,700 new units are significant and we need housing. But building housing is not the same as building for the community that's already here. Losing 800,000 square feet of manufacturing space means trading good working class jobs for development that may not serve the people who need it most. And adding that density to a neighborhood that is already third lowest in open space per capita without proportional green space investment is not growth. It is over-crowding. At the federal level, I will fight to condition any federal housing dollars flowing into OneLIC on real affordability standards. Permanently affordable means permanently affordable to the working families, artists, and manufacturers who built LIC, not benchmarked to area median incomes that don't reflect what people actually earn. I will push for federal investment in manufacturing retention so that industrial jobs don't simply disappear when a neighborhood gets rezoned. And I will fight for direct federal funding for waterfront green space and stormwater infrastructure because communities absorbing this level of density deserve the infrastructure to support it. The people who built a neighborhood should not be the first ones forced to leave when it changes. That principle guided my work for 20 years. It will guide me in Congress.

On public land, subsidies, and privatization

Public land should serve the public. I spent 20 years watching what happens when public resources get handed to private interests. Landlords who receive tax abatements and then fail to maintain buildings. Developers who get subsidies and then price out the community the subsidy was supposed to serve. This community knows this better than most. Amazon was offered \$3 billion in public incentives to build here and the community fought back and won. That fight proved what happens when people demand that public resources serve the public. My principles for public land: Public land should remain in public or community ownership. Transferring publicly owned sites to private developers should be the last option, not the first. If public land is developed, it must serve the community permanently, not just during a compliance window. That means deep affordability, community governance, and protections that outlast any single administration. Public subsidies should come with permanent public benefit. If a developer receives public money, the community should receive permanently affordable housing, community space, below market commercial space for small businesses and artists, and enforceable accountability. Community land trusts are a model I believe that works. They keep land in community hands permanently. The work WQCLT is doing is exactly the kind of community controlled development that should be the standard, not the exception.

The Anable Basin public sites — options selected

- No transfer of public land to private ownership of any kind.
- No new housing in the floodplain
- Community space
- Below market-rate commercial/retail space (subsidized and/or affordable to small businesses, working artists and nonprofits)
- Industrial/working artist/light manufacturing space
- Open public green space/park
- Waterfront public access
- Resilient waterfront green infrastructure (such as strategic retreat, seawalls, elevating shorelines, & wetlands) to mitigate flooding and sea level rise

Explanation of selections (as submitted):

These are publicly owned sites in a floodplain that was under six feet of water during Sandy. I do not support building housing of any kind in a floodplain without comprehensive resiliency infrastructure in place first. That applies to market-rate and affordable housing equally because the families who move into affordable units are the ones least able to recover from a flood. We should not put more people in harm's way. These sites should remain in public or community ownership. The community that fought off Amazon's \$3 billion handout earned the right to determine what happens on this land. And what should happen is what the private market will not deliver on its own. Below market space for artists and small manufacturers. Community space. Light industrial and workforce development space. Open green space and waterfront access. And critically, resilient green infrastructure that protects the entire waterfront, not just individual parcels.

I did not select market-rate housing or market-rate commercial space because the private market is already delivering plenty of both across LIC. Public land in a floodplain should be used to protect the community, not to put more people at risk.

On the 44-36 Vernon Blvd building

The WQCLT's vision for 44-36 Vernon Blvd is exactly what public land should be used for. Converting the building into a deeply affordable, community controlled, multi-tenant space for arts and culture, light manufacturing, workforce development, nonprofit services, and community retail is the right use of a public asset. This is the kind of community infrastructure I have spent my career building. At The Bronx Defenders and Neighborhood Defender Service in Harlem, I built spaces that connected communities to multiple services under one roof because the system was not doing it. The Queensboro People's Space does the same thing for a different set of needs in a different community. It is community driven, permanently affordable, and designed to serve the community it sits in. I will fight for federal funding to support community land trust projects like this. Community Development Block Grants (CDBG), which this administration has proposed eliminating, are exactly the kind of federal investment that should flow to projects like QPS. I will fight to restore and expand CDBG funding and direct it toward community controlled development.

On the floodplain and resiliency

Public resiliency infrastructure must come first. You cannot rely on individual developers to protect an entire waterfront. A developer prioritizes protecting their investment, not the entire floodplain. The city and state should not permit housing in the floodplain until comprehensive, publicly funded resiliency infrastructure is built and operational. Resilient green infrastructure, including wetlands, living shorelines, elevated parks, and strategic retreat where necessary,

should be the foundation, not an afterthought negotiated during Uniform Land Use Review Procedure (ULURP). At the federal level, I will push for legislation requiring resiliency infrastructure as a precondition for any development in a floodplain. In

Antonio Reynoso

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On growth and displacement

I grew up in a Section 8 apartment in Williamsburg, and I've seen first hand the profound impact both affordable homes and their scarcity can have on families and communities at large. NYC's housing crisis must be addressed, and I have spent my career fighting against the many forces which perpetuate it. I believe in a social housing model that sustainably provides permanently and deeply affordable housing that centers social ownership, community control, and the highest standards of dignified conditions for residents. Protecting existing community members is an integral part of this vision. That's why I worked to pass the Stand for Tenant Safety bill package during my time in the City Council—a series of regulations which protect tenants from landlords using construction as harassment. I will always hold housing development and tenant protection in balance, because I know that one should not exist without the other. I've proven that at the local level, and I hope to do so federally as well. As for manufacturing, as Borough President, I've been very clear that industrial jobs are not a thing of the past. They are one of the last real pathways to middle-class wages for immigrants, non-English speakers, and New Yorkers without college degrees. That's why my office released Making More: Industry's Role in an Affordable, Livable City, partnered with Made in NYC to spotlight local manufacturers, convened manufacturers, workforce groups, unions, and environmental justice leaders, and called for stronger Industrial Business Zones, full funding for Industrial Business Service Providers, green manufacturing jobs, and planning around freight and the Interborough Express. That same approach belongs in LIC.

On public land, subsidies, and privatization

I am a strong supporter of the Community Land Act, and though its legislation applies mostly to affordable housing, the principles at its core—public land for public good, prioritizing CLTs and non-profit developers whenever possible, and protecting and empowering tenants—guide my approach to the future of public land in general. To that end, I believe all New Yorkers should have access to public land, and public parkland especially. Nature should not be a privilege for the wealthy, and living in an urban area like New York City isn't an excuse not to provide residents with ample greenery. In my capacity as the Brooklyn Borough President, I've been working with Councilmember Lincoln Restler to convert a patch of public land into a park. The land is currently being used as a parking lot for municipal court judges despite the fact that it's officially parkland. Watching these judges park their luxury cars in space meant to benefit every Brooklynite has only reaffirmed my commitment to creating and sharing public land for and with the people it's always been meant for—the public.

The Anable Basin public sites — options selected

- No transfer of public land to private ownership of any kind.
- Deeply affordable housing (developed by not-for-profits, no market-rate units, all at AMIs below 60%)
- Market-rate housing (Mixed-income developer-built housing with existing MIH levels)
- No new housing in the floodplain

- Community space
- Below market-rate commercial/retail space (subsidized and/or affordable to small businesses, working artists and nonprofits)
- Market-rate commercial space
- Mixed-use housing, community and light manufacturing space
- Industrial/working artist/light manufacturing space
- New school
- Open public green space/park
- Waterfront public access
- Resilient waterfront green infrastructure (such as strategic retreat, seawalls, elevating shorelines, & wetlands) to mitigate flooding and sea level rise
- Working port/Blue highway

Explanation of selections (as submitted):

We desperately need to build deeply affordable housing, but we also must expand the supply of all types of housing. We are in a crisis and we need a crisis level response.

On the 44-36 Vernon Blvd building

Public land and public buildings should not automatically be handed over to private developers, demolished, and turned into another speculative housing project. Especially in a neighborhood like LIC, where public land is scarce and displacement pressure is intense, we should be asking: what can this public asset do for the people who already live and work here? We need deeply affordable housing, but we also need the jobs, social services, cultural spaces, small businesses, and industrial uses that allow people to actually stay. A public building of this scale should be used for permanent public benefit.

On the floodplain and resiliency

It's not a coincidence that low-income and public housing is usually built in areas prone to flooding. We simply shouldn't be building anywhere that we know will flood eventually unless we build the infrastructure to prevent it, not only because we'll only have to spend more money on repairs down the line, but also because it sets the residents who rely on affordable housing up for failure. If affordable housing is to truly serve the public, it must first be sustainable. The government must build out public resiliency infrastructure to protect our city and create strong union jobs. In addition to avoiding vulnerable land, we should also invest in building out our wetlands through projects like the Billion Oyster Project, which endeavours to restore oyster reefs to New York Harbor. These initiatives can protect the city from storm damage, and they increase biodiversity while preserving New Yorkers' access to the waterfront.

Claire Valdez

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On growth and displacement

This level of growth requires that we organize to protect those who are already living and working here, as well as fund the infrastructure and public goods needed to accommodate the current and future needs of Western Queens. Schools, sewage infrastructure, green space, and transportation upgrades are needed to support this growth for new and current residents. We need to increase per capita green space ratios, upgrade sewer and stormwater infrastructure,

expand transit capacity, redesign streets to alleviate traffic and improve street safety, and build new schools. But infrastructure investment alone isn't enough. Growth that isn't paired with permanent affordability protections will accelerate displacement. That means conditioning public subsidies on ensuring affordability, expanding rent stabilization, prioritizing community land trusts and social housing models that take land permanently off the speculative market, and ensuring that existing manufacturers, working artists, and community organizations have protected space – not just first right of refusal – in any new development.

On public land, subsidies, and privatization

I share the belief that public land should benefit and enrich the lives of the communities that surround it – not serve as a vehicle for private profit. To ensure that is the case, we must require community buy-in guiding any land use decisions at every stage of the process; not just meetings where public officials and developers take comments, but actual long-term involvement, where community leaders are asked to take on leadership and planning roles and guide strategic decision making from beginning to end, and local businesses and residents are given the first opportunity to take advantage of the space. Private entities operating on public land should not be beholden to shareholders or profit-maximization imperatives. The WQCLT represents a strong model for this kind of generative use of public land and buildings. Public land that goes to private developers, even with affordability requirements, risks reverting to market-rate use when those requirements expire. We need permanently affordable, community-controlled outcomes, not time-limited ones.

The Anable Basin public sites — options selected

- No transfer of public land to private ownership of any kind.
- Deeply affordable housing (developed by not-for-profits, no market-rate units, all at AMIs below 60%)
- No new housing in the floodplain
- Community space
- Below market-rate commercial/retail space (subsidized and/or affordable to small businesses, working artists and nonprofits)
- Mixed-use housing, community and light manufacturing space
- Industrial/working artist/light manufacturing space
- New school
- Open public green space/park
- Waterfront public access
- Resilient waterfront green infrastructure (such as strategic retreat, seawalls, elevating shorelines, & wetlands) to mitigate flooding and sea level rise
- Working port/Blue highway

Explanation of selections (as submitted):

The three public sites at Anable Basin represent a rare and potentially irreversible decision point. Once this land is disposed of, it's extraordinarily difficult to reclaim for public use. My selections reflect the principle that these sites should serve current and future community needs – not maximize land value for private developers. That means deeply affordable housing on any residential component, but also preserving and creating space for uses like working artists, light manufacturers, nonprofits, and small businesses. The affordability crisis isn't only about rent – it's also about the loss of affordable commercial and workspace that makes it impossible for artists, small manufacturers, and community organizations to remain in the neighborhood. Any

development on these sites should be done in the service of addressing this reality. I also support no new housing or commercial development in the floodplain, and any waterfront development should prioritize resilient green infrastructure and public access over private amenities.

On the 44-36 Vernon Blvd building

WQCLT's vision for the Queensboro People's Space at 44-36 Vernon Blvd is exactly the kind of community-led, multi-use development that public land should enable. Rather than demolishing an existing building for market-rate or even mixed-income housing, the proposal converts it into a deeply affordable, multi-tenant hub: working artists, light manufacturing, nonprofits, workforce development, and community retail – precisely the uses being pushed out of LIC, in part by the OneLIC rezoning. What I find compelling about this model is that it takes seriously something that gets lost in most affordability conversations: the crisis isn't only residential. When affordable workspace disappears, so do the artists, the small manufacturers, the community organizations, and the cultural fabric that make neighborhoods worth living in. WQCLT's plan addresses both. I fully support this vision and commit to pursuing capital funding from my office to help make it a reality.

On the floodplain and resiliency

The burden of flood protection should not fall on individual private developers, who will build to minimum requirements and pass costs to tenants or future buyers. Public resiliency infrastructure, like seawalls, wetlands, strategic retreat, and elevated shorelines, needs to be planned and funded publicly, with community input, at a scale that actually protects people.

Julie Won

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On growth and displacement

OneLIC locked in significant obligations: 13 acres of new public open space, waterfront esplanade connections, Queensbridge Park renovations, connectivity with the Con-Ed sites and Silvercup parcels, etc. But the EDC is a black box and has not yet issued RFPs for the public land - the community needs to know what the requirements will be. We need to keep their feet to the fire - community organizations (ie WQCLT and LICC-HPCC), housing advocates, and elected officials need to keep demanding transparency from the EDC and the mayor's office, and hold the line on the open space commitments that were made. On manufacturing: nonprofits and housing organizers need to hold the mayor's office accountable for any changes to IBZ uses.

On public land, subsidies, and privatization

As a member of Congress, I will not have direct jurisdiction over land use. However, like the current congresswoman Nydia Velasquez, I would tell my replacement in the council to support public land trusts especially the DOE building. I would also try to provide the same or more funding of land trust non profits as the sitting member. I still believe in comprehensive planning and centering community feedback. Like Nydia Velasquez I would try to attend as many public rallies and send staff to hearings and workshops to keep a close pulse on the community sentiment and not be afraid to protest/rally against the Mayor, Governor, or private developers during land use negotiations. I do acknowledge that with the changes of City of Yes, Props 2-4, and now Zohran Mamdani's "SPEED" reforms, Council Members and the general public will

have even less authority over rezonings so wherever I can use my voice to point out disparities and an imbalance of power for our community I will speak out.

The Anable Basin public sites — options selected

- No transfer of public land to private ownership of any kind.
- Market-rate housing (Mixed-income developer-built housing with existing MIH levels)
- Community space
- Below market-rate commercial/retail space (subsidized and/or affordable to small businesses, working artists and nonprofits)
- Market-rate commercial space
- Mixed-use housing, community and light manufacturing space
- Industrial/working artist/light manufacturing space
- New school
- Open public green space/park
- Waterfront public access
- Resilient waterfront green infrastructure (such as strategic retreat, seawalls, elevating shorelines, & wetlands) to mitigate flooding and sea level rise
- Working port/Blue highway

No additional explanation submitted.

On the 44-36 Vernon Blvd building

As a freshman member (and in a Congress under Republican control) I won't have access to this level of capital funding.

On the floodplain and resiliency

^See above - this requires federal attention and funding.

Assembly District 30

New York State Assembly • Democratic Primary, June 23, 2026

Also on the June 23 ballot: Somnath Ghimire. WQCLT did not receive a completed questionnaire from this candidate by the publication deadline.

Shamsul Haque

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On growth and displacement

Growth in Long Island City cannot only benefit luxury developers while longtime residents, small manufacturers, artists, and working families are pushed out. We need smart development that includes deeply affordable housing, protections for industrial and creative spaces, and real investment in infrastructure before more luxury projects are approved.

I support expanding waterfront parks and green space so Queens families — not just luxury towers — can enjoy and benefit from our waterfront. Development should strengthen communities, create union jobs, protect small businesses and artists, and improve quality of life for the people who already call LIC home.

On public land, subsidies, and privatization

My approach is simple: any use of public land or public subsidies must deliver clear benefits to the community, including deeply affordable housing, union jobs, public green space, schools, infrastructure, and protections for existing residents and small businesses.

I oppose privatization deals that give away public assets without accountability or long-term community benefit.

The Anable Basin public sites — options selected

- No transfer of public land to private ownership of any kind.
- Deeply affordable housing (developed by not-for-profits, no market-rate units, all at AMIs below 60%)
- Community space
- Open public green space/park
- Waterfront public access
- Resilient waterfront green infrastructure (such as strategic retreat, seawalls, elevating shorelines, & wetlands) to mitigate flooding and sea level rise

Explanation of selections (as submitted):

For these sites, I would prioritize deeply affordable housing, community space, new schools, public green space, resilient waterfront infrastructure, and below-market commercial space for small businesses, nonprofits, and working artists. Any development must include strong flood resiliency protections given the climate risks facing our waterfront communities. I also support preserving space for light manufacturing and working artists that are essential to the identity and economy of LIC.

On the 44-36 Vernon Blvd building

Yes — I support community-led development models like this that prioritize public benefit over luxury speculation. Preserving and repurposing the existing building for deeply affordable community-centered uses — including arts and culture, workforce development, nonprofits, light manufacturing, and affordable commercial space — is the kind of smart, sustainable development Queens needs.

On the floodplain and resiliency

Housing and development in the floodplain must be approached responsibly, with climate resiliency and public safety at the center of every decision. The city and state cannot continue approving large-scale development without first investing in the infrastructure needed to protect surrounding communities from flooding and sea level rise. Public resiliency infrastructure — including upgraded sewers, flood barriers, wetlands, raised shorelines, drainage systems, and waterfront parks that absorb stormwater — must come before major new development.

Patrick Martinez

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On growth and displacement

I sat on the OneLIC working group while this was being reviewed, discussed, and voted on. Additionally, I have been an active member of Queens Community Board 2's Land Use Committee for years. As such, I supported the Community Board's overall support with highlighted stipulations - which included a preference for deeply affordable housing under MIH options, affordable production space for artists, and establishment of a commercial displacement fund. In office I would continue to monitor developments of this rezoning to ensure the newly formed Oversight Task Force has the tools needed to ensure promises are kept and developers are held accountable to the community.

On public land, subsidies, and privatization

Public land is a community asset, and should be used for the public good. If a land use is not for the public good, then it is not a good use for public land. I am generally opposed to transferring public land to private land owners and am hard-pressed to think of a compelling reason to transfer public land into private ownership. Public subsidies and privatization should only be applied in instances where the city or state is unable to utilize the land for the public to benefit from directly, such as an empty lot that for whichever reason cannot be converted into park space or some other use.

The Anable Basin public sites — options selected

- Deeply affordable housing (developed by not-for-profits, no market-rate units, all at AMIs below 60%)
- Market-rate housing (Mixed-income developer-built housing with existing MIH levels)
- Community space
- Mixed-use housing, community and light manufacturing space
- Open public green space/park
- Waterfront public access
- Resilient waterfront green infrastructure (such as strategic retreat, seawalls, elevating shorelines, & wetlands) to mitigate flooding and sea level rise

Explanation of selections (as submitted):

When discussing these plots and potential use cases, I was a big advocate for increasing the housing supply though I put extra preference on deeply affordable MIH options. While not-for-profit developers with units set at a ceiling of 60% AMI may be ideal - it may not be feasible if no not-for-profit takes up the project. That is why mixed-income housing, with deeply affordable MIH options, is also an option I would potentially support. While increasing the housing supply is critical, including multiple uses in this space will give the neighborhood a vibrant feeling with shops and community space. This would be great for residents and attract commuters and other guests as well along the waterfront. Along the waterfront itself we should keep this land open for the public to enjoy, though resiliency and flood mitigation designs should be incorporated as well.

On the 44-36 Vernon Blvd building

I understand this community-led vision supports a number of industries concurrently, an excellent application of Jane Jacob's idea of vitality in urban spaces. With that, housing is the most acute shortage we have currently in the city. Expanding supply responsibly is key to relieving some of the pressure on housing costs. A larger building may be able to increase the housing supply, while potentially including arts and culture, nonprofit social services, and community retail tenants on lower levels, and do so with more energy-efficient systems in place.

On the floodplain and resiliency

We need an honest, aggressive paradigm shift when dealing with the floodplain because the city and state have relied far too heavily on individual protections built by private developers. This current strategy results in isolated luxury buildings that function as flood-resistant fortresses while pushing displaced floodwaters into the surrounding, older, and less protected blocks. The state must lead on regional, public resiliency infrastructure by funding restored wetlands, and expanded shoreline elevations that protect the entire community collectively.

Assembly District 36

New York State Assembly • Democratic Primary, June 23, 2026

Also on the June 23 ballot: Rana Abdelhamid, Shivani Dhir. WQCLT did not receive completed questionnaires from these candidates by the publication deadline.

Mary Jobaida

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On growth and displacement

Great question. For 25 years, this has been my issue of greatest engagement as an organizer - I have lived in LIC since 2001, when it was primarily a neighborhood of townhouses and smaller buildings. The extreme gentrification and concomitant reduction in open space has been an absolute tragedy of mass privatization of NYC neighborhoods. It's an object lesson in what can go wrong when those in power care more about developers' interests than in the checks and balances that keep neighborhoods affordable, vibrant and diverse. First of all, community land trusts in and of themselves are a major part of the solution - we need control over common space to be dictated by the community and a democratic process, NOT by raw capitalism. A gigantic amount of the new housing stock is either empty or serves as a pied-a-terre - which means, effectively, that space for humans is being swapped out for absolutely nothing of value, except to ultra-wealthy investors. This is not a community, subject to local accountability or even regular market forces. This is theft from what rightfully belongs to the public.

I like the Mayor and Governor's taxation regime on second homes, and I think it doesn't go far enough. I think communities need more of a direct planning process for land use overall and more of a say in where money generated from and in their communities goes, and CLTs are the best model for how to begin.

On public land, subsidies, and privatization

Privatization is a tactic I believe should only be used for services government is incapable of doing or over which it can save money and maintain accountability (including the implementation of clawback provisions for failure to meet targets and standards) by outsourcing, which is, at the end of the day, a small list (for example, manufacturing, supply of needed goods, and other market operations at scale). In some cases, it may help to engage the private sector in remediation work for contaminated sites. Public land should, otherwise, remain public, and the upkeep thereof, while obviously subject to case-by-case review, should be accountable to the local community, either through a nonprofit CLT or through direct community governance. Public subsidies are important to the maintenance of housing as a community investment; their exact target would depend on the model chosen by each community to keep housing affordable, high-quality and under community control.

The Anable Basin public sites — options selected

- No transfer of public land to private ownership of any kind.
- Deeply affordable housing (developed by not-for-profits, no market-rate units, all at AMIs below 60%)
- No new housing in the floodplain
- Community space

- Below market-rate commercial/retail space (subsidized and/or affordable to small businesses, working artists and nonprofits)
- Mixed-use housing, community and light manufacturing space
- Industrial/working artist/light manufacturing space
- New school
- Open public green space/park
- Waterfront public access
- Resilient waterfront green infrastructure (such as strategic retreat, seawalls, elevating shorelines, & wetlands) to mitigate flooding and sea level rise
- Working port/Blue highway

Explanation of selections (as submitted):

I selected so many because I am not an urban planner, and so would need to consult with experts - but most importantly, those experts should advise the community and we should determine the mix of uses that way!

I am opposing market-rate units of housing or commerce because those are the standard contemporary uses of waterfront property, and these developments have only stratified wealth inequality while having little to show for it beyond a more crowded skyline and less space available to displaced residents and businesses.

On the 44-36 Vernon Blvd building

This is a prime example of a community picking its own optimal route forward with space usage, and that is exactly what should be honored unless there are ever overriding concerns about pollution, safety or the larger planning grid.

On the floodplain and resiliency

Spots where resiliency infrastructure is needed are non-negotiable. Space may be at a premium for all kinds of uses, but there is nothing more expensive for all concerned than building nonresilient infrastructure that will necessarily be destroyed and need cleanup, not to mention both the opportunity cost and possible aggravation of other areas' resiliency issues from failure to act on the local one.

Private developers must be held to maximum standards of insurance, infrastructure and tenant safety when building in a high-risk area such as a floodplain (in reverse order of importance). The City should, in my opinion, adopt a comprehensive, community-informed (but centrally-controlled) resiliency plan for the entire City landmass, ensure that each pocket of the City remains protected by redundant systems with guaranteed long-term funding and maintenance, and only then release the ability to build on top of that to the communities involved, as directly as possible.

Diana Moreno

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On growth and displacement

To balance growth in Long Island City, I'd build off of the housing agenda Mayor Zohran Mamdani is pursuing. I've been very supportive of the way in which Mayor Mamdani has paired new development with deep investments in tenant organizing and code enforcement, which will

protect vulnerable renters from harassment and displacement. But we need more investment to make this possible. My own personal framework for growth is based on the principle that every person in Queens, whether they be a recent immigrant or a long-term resident, should have the opportunity to reside and raise a family here. To accomplish this, I'll look to funding efforts to improve green space in Long Island City with my office's capital funds. I will work closely with organizations like the Western Queens CLT and local makers to identify opportunities to preserve small-scale manufacturing jobs in the community, and will also support organizations such as tenant unions in my district that help residents organize against greedy, irresponsible landlords and the threat of displacement.

On public land, subsidies, and privatization

To me, the root cause of New York's housing crisis is simple—land is treated like a commodity, instead of an ecological resource, or, when developed with housing, a place where we live, raise families, and build community. Today, landlords of privately-owned, non-rent regulated buildings can profit off of the homes of tenants by raising the rent or refusing to make even the most basic repairs. Speculators rake in millions by purchasing buildings, not to live in them, but to sell them for more than they purchased them for. Despite there being a shortage of over 600,000 affordable homes in New York State, developers build housing for the wealthiest among us, not working-class people struggling to make ends meet. We can't get out of this crisis with tax breaks for developers or privately-managed housing programs—these interventions will never meet New York's growing shortage of affordable housing. Instead, we'll need to transform our relationship to land. I will prioritize protecting our public land. When affordable housing or other development projects are built on public sites, I will advocate to stop the disposition of these sites to private developers and prioritize keeping public ownership whenever possible. Furthermore, while I oppose the concept of corporate welfare for the real estate industry, I will try to extract maximum community incentives, such as affordability mandates or infrastructure upgrades, from any and all private developers seeking state level tax breaks. Public land should remain in public hands!

The Anable Basin public sites — options selected

- No transfer of public land to private ownership of any kind.
- Deeply affordable housing (developed by not-for-profits, no market-rate units, all at AMIs below 60%)
- Community space
- Below market-rate commercial/retail space (subsidized and/or affordable to small businesses, working artists and nonprofits)
- Mixed-use housing, community and light manufacturing space
- Industrial/working artist/light manufacturing space
- New school
- Open public green space/park
- Waterfront public access
- Resilient waterfront green infrastructure (such as strategic retreat, seawalls, elevating shorelines, & wetlands) to mitigate flooding and sea level rise
- Working port/Blue highway
- Childcare centers (write-in addition by the candidate)

Explanation of selections (as submitted):

Something I would be interested in exploring (in partnership with the Western Queens Community Land Trust) would be advocating for money in the state budget to support a pilot social housing program on these public sites. Assemblymember Sarahana Shrestha won \$8 million in funding for a social housing pilot in Ulster County through this year's state budget. I would love to pursue a similar project on a publicly owned site in LIC that could combine many of the crucial community services proposed in the Hunters Point North Resiliency Vision Plan with union-built, permanently affordable housing, where rent is capped at 25% of resident income.

On the 44-36 Vernon Blvd building

I am proud to support this project! The Queensboro People's Space would provide so many vital community services, such as affordable spaces for arts and culture programming, social services, and job training. I love the idea of locating a food co-op on site, and am excited the proposal also would help to preserve LIC's vibrant manufacturing history by dedicating space for small-scale and light manufacturing businesses, which have struggled to stay in New York City. As a mom, I'm also personally excited by the proposed daycare in the QPS. This space would provide worker-cooperatives, artists, community members, makers, and caregivers with a much needed respite in our increasingly expensive city, and I'd be excited to support this crucial project with capital funding once we have an assessment of how much we will be receiving and the district's needs.

On the floodplain and resiliency

I agree that mitigating climate risk and expanding access to public green space must be the two cornerstones of new development in Long Island City. As the Vision Plan notes, it is not particularly close to transit and is in a flood zone. However, due to the shortage of public land available for housing development in New York City, I do believe that some public sites should be dedicated in part to publicly-funded, permanently affordable housing development. While the location of the sites are not ideal, the dwindling supply of public land makes publicly-stewarded, permanently affordable housing developments on public sites in this area a necessary investment in affordability for Western Queens. To approach housing development successfully in the floodplain, two things will be essential: deep investment in resiliency infrastructure, like the sewer improvements called for in the Vision Plan, and pulling waterfront development back from the shoreline as much as possible. In an area with so much public land, the city (and state) must invest deeply in green infrastructure that reduces sewer overflow, stormwater flooding, and increases stormwater permeability in the case of storm surge flooding. Oftentimes, waterfront developments involve private developers providing privately-owned public spaces along the city's shoreline. In Long Island City, we cannot accept this private capture of a public resource. As the Vision Plan notes, developing a connected, public waterfront park along the shoreline of Long Island City is the best way to ensure the community has access to the waterfront, while also ensuring that the park provides the necessary resiliency features to protect the community from flooding. I will invest in public resiliency infrastructure in LIC, such as the proposed waterfront park, stormwater flooding prevention, an enhanced tree cover, and other necessary improvements.

Assembly District 37

New York State Assembly • Democratic Primary, June 23, 2026

Samantha Kattan

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On growth and displacement

I have dedicated my career to protecting tenants and working class homeowners (in limited-equity coops), frequently in the context of increased development pressure. I would dedicate resources from my office to support tenant organizing and to share KYR information for tenants protected by rent stabilization or good cause eviction. I would also fight for commercial rent stabilization (AM Gallagher's legislation) to protect manufacturing spaces, small businesses and artist studios. Additionally, I was partially inspired to run for office because as a new mom I have personally been so frustrated by the lack of adequate green space across district 37; this is largely in the purview of the city, but I would advocate for the Parks department to fast track their development of new neighborhood parks and advocate for increased waterfront green space.

On public land, subsidies, and privatization

Given our current available tools, I believe in prioritizing the transfer of public land to nonprofit owners and CLTs to develop permanently and deeply affordable housing, commercial space and community space. However, I am running for state office in part because I believe that the current tools we have at the city level for developing affordable housing are insufficient (they have not managed to create enough housing at the affordability levels needed to truly address our housing crisis, and for-profit owners are too often the winners of RFPs for redeveloping public land), and I hope to push for the creation of a Social Housing Development Authority which would be a public developer and owner of deeply affordable housing.

The Anable Basin public sites — options selected

- Deeply affordable housing (developed by not-for-profits, no market-rate units, all at AMIs below 60%)
- Community space
- Below market-rate commercial/retail space (subsidized and/or affordable to small businesses, working artists and nonprofits)
- Mixed-use housing, community and light manufacturing space
- Industrial/working artist/light manufacturing space
- Open public green space/park
- Waterfront public access
- Resilient waterfront green infrastructure (such as strategic retreat, seawalls, elevating shorelines, & wetlands) to mitigate flooding and sea level rise

Explanation of selections (as submitted):

Generally I am in support of a mix of 100% affordable housing and commercial space and green space. School siting is complex but if community input and DOE align on the need for an additional school in this location, I would be in support of siting it there as well. I would also be interested in hearing more about how these sites could function as a working port.

On the 44-36 Vernon Blvd building

Yes I'm familiar with and support this project (which is not in AD37 but is nearby!). I would open up an application for capital funding requests but I will be clear about my intent to prioritize funding projects that are aligned with my vision of supporting tenant and community ownership of land.

On the floodplain and resiliency

I believe we need to invest heavily in resiliency infrastructure in the face of climate change, including rising sea levels and increased instances of heavy rainfall. I will favor public ownership of land and park space where possible versus relying on private developers to address our resiliency needs. I support the Hunters Point North Vision Plan which seems to balance new residential and commercial development with open space and multiple forms of resiliency infrastructure.

Melissa Orlando

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On growth and displacement

LIC needs more housing but not at the expense of businesses that have made LIC what it is today. Projects like OneLIC need to be accompanied by strong anti-displacement protections and affordability requirements that incorporate community input throughout the process. A main concern would be preserving space for small businesses that contribute to the economic and cultural fabric of the neighborhood. Development needs to create opportunities for existing residents rather than push them out. At the same time this needs to be balanced with the challenge of land shortage, an increase in density must be matched in investments in parks, waterfront access, and community infrastructure. I support the expansion of the public waterfront and greenspace, creating new parks and recreational areas, ensuring that environmental sustainability remains central to future development decisions. Ensuring these growth opportunities benefits the community and not just developers means affordable housing, displacement protections and the preservation of jobs and public spaces.

On public land, subsidies, and privatization

I agree completely that public land should serve the public. Publicly owned sites should be used to address community needs and not simply maximize profits for private developers. As Western Queens continue to grow my guiding principle will be ensuring that public land is used to create permanently affordable housing that serves the populations that need it the most. Affordable housing means more than just building affordable units. It means making sure long term residents can remain in their neighborhoods by increasing enforcement on bad landlords, community controlled development, and strengthening rent stabilization to prevent displacement before it occurs.

I support increasing funding for affordable housing programs and land trusts and ensuring that development on public land includes substantial affordable housing that is accurately affordable for the community. Public subsidies should be tied to public benefits and hold strong accountability, not used for luxury developments that fail to meet community needs. Furthermore, these decisions must incorporate residents in the decision making process. Many major developments move forward without adequate community input throughout the development process. Ultimately, my goal is to make sure public assets are used to strengthen

and support our communities, expand affordable housing, and protect long term residents from displacement.

The Anable Basin public sites — options selected

- Deeply affordable housing (developed by not-for-profits, no market-rate units, all at AMIs below 60%)
- Community space
- Below market-rate commercial/retail space (subsidized and/or affordable to small businesses, working artists and nonprofits)
- Industrial/working artist/light manufacturing space
- New school
- Open public green space/park
- Waterfront public access
- Resilient waterfront green infrastructure (such as strategic retreat, seawalls, elevating shorelines, & wetlands) to mitigate flooding and sea level rise
- Working port/Blue highway

No additional explanation submitted.

On the 44-36 Vernon Blvd building

Yes, I support WQCLT's feasibility study and RFEI response to the EDC for the 44-36 Vernon Blvd site to convert the building into a deeply affordable, multi-tenant space rather than demolishing it for housing. A community-led proposal that supports local businesses and nonprofit social services will create the kind of development that strengthens neighborhoods without displacing residents that I would commit capital funding to.

On the floodplain and resiliency

Public resilience infrastructure must serve as the foundation for protecting the waterfront. Large-scale flood barriers, waterfront parks, and upgraded sewer systems cannot be built without government funding. At the same time private developers have the responsibility to ensure their projects meet resilience requirements that have been set by the community and existing infrastructure. Developers should not rely completely on public investments and avoid taking their own steps to mitigate climate risks. I would lean towards no additional housing in the floodplain.

Pia Rahman

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On growth and displacement

Long Island City's growth presents both opportunities and challenges. Growth should not come at the expense of the residents, artists, and manufacturers who helped build the character and economic foundation of the community. My approach would be to ensure that development is community-centered, equitable, and designed to protect the people and spaces that make LIC unique.

I would support stronger anti-displacement measures, including expanded tenant protections, increased investment in deeply affordable housing, and policies that prioritize long-term affordability rather than luxury development alone. As neighborhoods grow, the people who

already live there should be able to remain in their communities and benefit from new investments rather than being priced out.

I also recognize that manufacturers and artists are essential parts of LIC's identity and economy. I would support protecting industrial and creative spaces from speculative development pressures, preserving mixed-use and manufacturing areas where appropriate, and exploring grants, affordable workspaces, and incentives that help small manufacturers and artists remain rooted in the community. Economic development should support diverse local ecosystems, not replace them. Waterfront development should also prioritize public access, climate resilience, and environmental justice. I would advocate for expanding accessible green space, creating connected waterfront parks and open spaces, and investing in resilient infrastructure that protects communities from flooding and climate impacts. Public waterfronts should serve the people who live in surrounding neighborhoods, not become exclusive amenities attached to private development. Ultimately, I believe growth should be measured not just by the number of new buildings constructed, but by whether existing residents, workers, artists, and families can continue to live, work, and thrive in the communities they helped create.

On public land, subsidies, and privatization

My approach to public land and public buildings would be guided by the principles of equity, transparency, community benefit, and long-term public value. Public assets belong to the people, and decisions about their future should prioritize the needs of residents rather than short-term private interests or speculative development.

I believe public land should be used to advance public goals, including affordable housing, community services, schools, healthcare facilities, open green space, cultural spaces, and infrastructure that strengthens neighborhoods. When public resources are involved, communities should see meaningful and lasting benefits, particularly in neighborhoods that have historically experienced underinvestment or displacement pressures.

I also believe any use of public subsidies should come with strong accountability measures. If taxpayer dollars are supporting private development projects, there should be clear requirements for affordability, labor standards, environmental sustainability, accessibility, and community benefit. Public subsidies should not function as blank checks for projects that generate private profit without delivering meaningful public value.

I would approach privatization cautiously. There may be circumstances where partnerships are appropriate, but I do not support privatization that reduces public access, weakens accountability, or transfers essential public assets into arrangements that primarily benefit private interests. Once public resources are lost, communities often have limited ability to regain control over them. Most importantly, I believe residents should have a meaningful voice in shaping these decisions. Community engagement should happen early and throughout the process, not after decisions have already been made. Public land should remain a tool for creating stronger, more equitable communities and protecting the long-term needs of the people who live there.

The Anable Basin public sites — options selected

- No transfer of public land to private ownership of any kind.
- Deeply affordable housing (developed by not-for-profits, no market-rate units, all at AMIs below 60%)
- Market-rate housing (Mixed-income developer-built housing with existing MIH levels)
- No new housing in the floodplain

- Community space
- Below market-rate commercial/retail space (subsidized and/or affordable to small businesses, working artists and nonprofits)
- Market-rate commercial space
- Mixed-use housing, community and light manufacturing space
- Industrial/working artist/light manufacturing space
- New school
- Open public green space/park
- Waterfront public access
- Resilient waterfront green infrastructure (such as strategic retreat, seawalls, elevating shorelines, & wetlands) to mitigate flooding and sea level rise
- Working port/Blue highway

No additional explanation submitted.

On the 44-36 Vernon Blvd building

I support community-led planning efforts that prioritize affordability, cultural preservation, workforce development, and long-term public benefit, and I believe the vision outlined for the 44-36 Vernon Boulevard site reflects many of those values. Preserving space for artists, light manufacturing, nonprofit services, workforce opportunities, and community-centered retail recognizes that neighborhoods need more than housing alone—they need ecosystems that allow residents, workers, and local institutions to thrive. I am particularly supportive of models that protect deeply affordable spaces and help prevent the displacement of artists, small businesses, nonprofit organizations, and working-class communities that have historically contributed to the identity and economic fabric of Long Island City. Community-driven development should create spaces that are accessible and beneficial to the people who already live and work in the neighborhood. Regarding capital funding, I would be open to strongly advocating for and pursuing capital investments if elected, while also evaluating the proposal through a lens of feasibility, community input, long-term sustainability, and measurable public benefit. I believe public funding should support projects that provide lasting value and broad community impact, and I would work collaboratively with stakeholders to identify funding opportunities and ensure resources are used effectively and equitably. My broader approach is that public land and public resources should serve public needs, and I would welcome continued engagement with community organizations and residents to ensure any project reflects those principles.

On the floodplain and resiliency

The city and state should approach development in floodplain areas with a long-term climate resilience framework that prioritizes safety, environmental sustainability, and community protection over short-term development pressures. As climate risks increase, we cannot continue planning as if sea level rise and severe storms are isolated events. Development decisions made today will affect communities for decades.

I believe housing can still be part of floodplain planning, but it must be done thoughtfully and responsibly. Any development in vulnerable areas should meet strong resiliency standards and avoid creating future risks for residents. We should prioritize resilient design, protect critical infrastructure, and carefully assess where development is appropriate rather than pursuing growth without considering long-term consequences. At the same time, I do not believe responsibility should fall primarily on individual private developers to create isolated protections

for individual projects. While developers should absolutely be required to meet high resiliency standards and contribute to mitigation efforts, climate resilience is fundamentally a public responsibility that requires coordinated investment. Floodwaters and climate impacts do not stop at property lines, and piecemeal solutions cannot fully protect neighborhoods. Public resiliency infrastructure should play a leading role because it creates broader, interconnected protections that benefit entire communities. Investments such as flood barriers, wetlands restoration, resilient waterfront parks, stormwater management systems, and green infrastructure can protect homes, businesses, transportation systems, and public spaces while also providing environmental and quality-of-life benefits.

I also believe resiliency planning must be rooted in environmental justice. Vulnerable communities should not bear disproportionate climate risks or be displaced by climate adaptation efforts. Public investments should strengthen neighborhoods and protect residents while ensuring that waterfront planning remains accessible, equitable, and community-driven.

Senate District 12

New York State Senate • Democratic Primary, June 23, 2026

Aber Kawas

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On growth and displacement

Western Queens cannot continue to absorb massive growth without protecting the people and communities that already built this neighborhood. I support a development model centered on deeply affordable housing, anti-displacement protections, preservation of manufacturing and arts spaces, and major investments in public infrastructure and green space. As someone who has lived in Queens and organized with working-class and immigrant communities, I've seen how luxury-focused rezonings often push out artists, small businesses, and longtime residents while giving communities very little in return. Growth cannot simply mean more luxury towers — it has to mean a better quality of life for existing residents as well. That includes preserving industrial jobs, supporting cultural institutions and artists, protecting rent-stabilized housing, and significantly expanding publicly accessible waterfront space and parks in LIC.

On public land, subsidies, and privatization

Public land should serve the public — not private luxury developers. My approach would prioritize permanently affordable housing, community ownership models, nonprofit and cultural space, union jobs, light manufacturing, and public infrastructure over privatization and speculative development. I strongly believe that when public subsidies are used, the public should receive meaningful long-term benefits in return: deeply affordable housing, community facilities, public open space, workforce development, and protections against displacement. We cannot continue giving away public assets without accountability to the people who live here.

The Anable Basin public sites — options selected

- Deeply affordable housing (developed by not-for-profits, no market-rate units, all at AMIs below 60%)
- No new housing in the floodplain
- Community space
- Below market-rate commercial/retail space (subsidized and/or affordable to small businesses, working artists and nonprofits)
- Mixed-use housing, community and light manufacturing space
- Industrial/working artist/light manufacturing space
- New school
- Open public green space/park
- Waterfront public access
- Resilient waterfront green infrastructure (such as strategic retreat, seawalls, elevating shorelines, & wetlands) to mitigate flooding and sea level rise
- Childcare centers (write-in addition by the candidate)

Explanation of selections (as submitted):

These sites should be developed through a community-centered process that prioritizes deeply affordable housing, resiliency infrastructure, cultural and manufacturing space, and public

amenities — not luxury development. I would support mixed-use models that include nonprofit community space, workforce development, artist and maker spaces, childcare, and public waterfront access. Given the flood risks in the area, any development must also be climate-conscious and designed around long-term resiliency and environmental sustainability.

On the 44-36 Vernon Blvd building

Yes, I strongly support the Queensboro People's Space vision. I believe preserving and repurposing existing public buildings for deeply affordable community-centered uses is far more valuable than simply demolishing them for private development. A space that supports arts and culture, workforce development, nonprofit services, community retail, and light manufacturing reflects the kind of people-first development Western Queens needs. As State Senator, I would absolutely advocate for and pursue capital funding opportunities to help make this vision a reality.

On the floodplain and resiliency

Housing and development in floodplains must be approached with extreme caution. The public sector should lead resiliency planning at the neighborhood level, rather than relying on fragmented, building-by-building protections from private developers. Developers who profit from waterfront development should absolutely contribute to resiliency investments, but the city and state must establish strong public standards and infrastructure that protect entire communities — not just individual properties.

Steven Raga

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On growth and displacement

New developments and projects should not come at the displacement of our community — they should be adding resources, housing, infrastructure, and community space to support residents.

In the Assembly, I have fought to preserve affordable housing and protect working families, including securing increased investments in the Mitchell-Lama program from \$80 million to \$110 million, which has helped residents in the Big Six buildings in Woodside remain in their homes. For LIC, I will continue to fight for affordable housing for all residents and will advocate for deeply affordable housing with preferences for local residents, strong tenant protections, and investments in permanently affordable housing models such as community land trusts. We cannot allow longtime residents to be priced out of the neighborhoods they helped build.

I support preserving and expanding affordable workspaces for residents, artists, and small businesses, particularly on publicly owned land. Public assets should be leveraged to create community benefits, good-paying jobs, and long-term affordability rather than simply maximizing private profit. New development should be paired with investments in climate-resilient waterfront infrastructure, recreation areas, and community spaces so that growth improves quality of life for everyone.

On public land, subsidies, and privatization

Before becoming an elected official, I have been involved in community organizing around land and development — whether it was organizing tenants and small businesses against a megachurch or my time on the Western Queens Community Land Trust board, because I believe that public land, our land, belongs to the community not for profit. As an Assemblymember, I have been guided by how much my actions would improve the community.

Publicly owned land is a limited resource that should be used to meet public needs, not transferred to private developers for luxury development. In a rapidly changing neighborhood like Western Queens, public land should be prioritized for permanently affordable housing, community facilities, open space, and affordable spaces for manufacturers, artists, and small businesses that are increasingly at risk of displacement.

I also believe that decisions about public land should be made transparently and with meaningful community participation. Public subsidies should only be used for projects that provide lasting public benefits, such as affordable housing, good-paying jobs, and community services. Once public land is privatized, the public loses a powerful tool for shaping the future of the neighborhood. My priority is to preserve public assets for public purposes and ensure they continue serving residents for generations to come.

The Anable Basin public sites — options selected

- No transfer of public land to private ownership of any kind.
- Deeply affordable housing (developed by not-for-profits, no market-rate units, all at AMIs below 60%)
- Community space
- Below market-rate commercial/retail space (subsidized and/or affordable to small businesses, working artists and nonprofits)
- Open public green space/park
- Waterfront public access
- Resilient waterfront green infrastructure (such as strategic retreat, seawalls, elevating shorelines, & wetlands) to mitigate flooding and sea level rise

Explanation of selections (as submitted):

Public land should be used to do the most good as possible and serve those who are often kicked out or marginalized by market rate housing and development projects.

On the 44-36 Vernon Blvd building

I have been a longtime supporter of the Queensboro People's Space since my time on the WQCLT board because it reflects principles that I strongly believe in: preserving public assets for public use, preventing displacement, creating economic opportunity, and ensuring that community members have a voice in shaping the future of their neighborhood. Rather than demolishing a publicly owned building and turning it over to private development, this proposal seeks to create permanently affordable space for artists, light manufacturers, nonprofit organizations, workforce development programs, and community-serving businesses. That kind of community-centered investment is especially important in Long Island City, where rising costs continue to threaten the diverse groups that have long contributed to the neighborhood's character and economy. As Senator, I will committing capital funding to support a project like Queensboro People's Space, provided there is a clear implementation plan, broad community support, and demonstrated long-term public benefit. I believe public dollars should be used to strengthen community ownership, create good jobs, expand access to affordable space, and deliver services that residents need. I would work with community organizations, local stakeholders, and government partners to explore funding opportunities and help advance projects that keep public resources in public service while building a more equitable future for Western Queens.

On the floodplain and resiliency

I support investments in comprehensive, publicly accessible resiliency infrastructure along the Western Queens waterfront, and I would be open to committing capital funding from my office to projects that demonstrate clear public benefits, strong community support, and long-term climate resilience. As sea levels rise and extreme weather events become more frequent, we need solutions that protect entire neighborhoods rather than relying solely on piecemeal measures. Public investments in flood protection, green infrastructure, and waterfront parks can help safeguard residents, businesses, and critical infrastructure while expanding much-needed open space. The city and state should take a cautious and forward-looking approach to development in the floodplain. New development must meet the highest resiliency standards, but we cannot rely exclusively on protections built by individual developers. Climate risks do not stop at property lines, and private flood mitigation measures often leave surrounding communities vulnerable. Public resiliency infrastructure—including flood barriers, living shorelines, stormwater management systems, and flood-absorbing parks—should serve as the foundation of our response because they provide protection at the neighborhood scale. At the same time, developers should be required to contribute to these broader resiliency efforts and ensure that new projects do not increase climate risks for surrounding communities. My priority is a resilient waterfront that protects residents, preserves public access, and prepares Western Queens for the realities of climate change.

Senate District 59

New York State Senate • Democratic Primary, June 23, 2026

Also on the June 23 ballot: Gus Lambropoulos. WQCLT did not receive a completed questionnaire from this candidate by the publication deadline.

Kristen Gonzalez

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On growth and displacement

I've been engaged in the OneLIC process from the beginning by attending public meetings, testifying before community boards, and writing publicly about what's at stake. LIC added over 20,000 housing units between 2010 and 2020, growing our population by 78%, and the neighborhood has struggled with the impacts ever since: traffic, a lack of school seats, overtaxed stormwater infrastructure, and minimal expansion of open space. OneLIC proposes 14,700 more units — an estimated 30,000 new neighbors in the next decade — and it's incredibly important we get this right. LIC's identity as an arts and culture hub depends on whether people can actually afford to stay here. The same principle applies to manufacturers: those jobs can't simply be relocated, and any plan that doesn't protect that space with binding requirements will accelerate the displacement we're trying to prevent. LIC already has the third worst open space ratio in the city, and this plan was projected to decrease that ratio by another 18.6 percent. The investments secured through OneLIC are an important step, but they must be part of a comprehensive open space strategy, not a one time fix. That means finally completing a continuous waterfront esplanade from Queensbridge to Gantry Plaza, and treating green space as the critical infrastructure it is for a neighborhood that has gone too long without it.

On public land, subsidies, and privatization

Publicly-owned sites should stay in public hands, with any vision for development being driven by the local community. Public subsidies should close the gap for projects that genuinely need them, not flow to developers who would build here anyway. Over the last decade, thousands of lots have been transferred from public to private ownership, with very few binding long-term affordability requirements. This is exactly why we need to see an increase in public ownership and specifically community land trusts. In my time in office, I have also been supporting Green Social Housing, creating a Social Housing Development Authority, deep investments in NYCHA, worker housing, and supportive housing. The baseline principals of affordability and holistic support for the most marginalized and working class communities are what should guide us.

The Anable Basin public sites — options selected

- No transfer of public land to private ownership of any kind.
- Deeply affordable housing (developed by not-for-profits, no market-rate units, all at AMIs below 60%)
- Community space
- Below market-rate commercial/retail space (subsidized and/or affordable to small businesses, working artists and nonprofits)
- Open public green space/park
- Waterfront public access

- Resilient waterfront green infrastructure (such as strategic retreat, seawalls, elevating shorelines, & wetlands) to mitigate flooding and sea level rise

No additional explanation submitted.

On the 44-36 Vernon Blvd building

Yes. Before I was elected, I organized with the Western Queens Community Land Trust, so I understand firsthand what this kind of community-controlled vision can deliver and how rare it is to have a city-owned building on the table as an opportunity to realize it. Converting the 44-36 Vernon Blvd site into a deeply affordable multi-tenant space for arts and culture, light manufacturing, workforce development, and nonprofit services is a far better use of that building than demolishing it, which would have negative environmental effects including the release of sequestered carbon and impacts on air quality and noise pollution. Investing in these affordable non-residential uses will ensure residents have access to a wide variety of services as the neighborhood grows. This will keep good jobs in the community and allow long-term residents, artists, and non-profits to continue serving their clients without displacement and speculation. I've committed capital funding to similar projects before — including \$1 million to the Chocolate Factory Theater for a multipurpose arts and community renovation — and I'm committed to working with WQCLT to identify and secure the capital funding needed to make this vision a reality.

On the floodplain and resiliency

In my public testimony on OneLIC, I raised concern about approving high-density residential development below the 50-year floodplain without fully understanding the consequences. As sea levels rise and storms intensify, the city and state need to be honest about that when making development decisions. The core problem with leaving flood protection to individual developers is that it produces a patchwork that protects no one reliably. That's why public resiliency infrastructure has to come first, not as a condition that gets negotiated alongside a development approval, but as something already in place before density is added.

I've been working to move state investment in that direction, including securing \$4 million for waterfront resiliency at Rainey Park in this year's budget.

— End of candidate responses —

Questions about this document: info@wqclt.org